

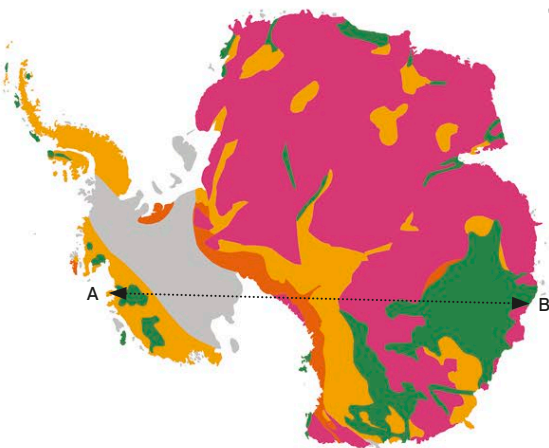
ECOSYSTEMS

The extreme cold means most forms of life are confined to the surrounding waters, but animals such as midges and penguins do survive on the ice.



KEY

- Precambrian (pre-541 million years ago)
- Paleozoic (541-252 million years ago)
- Mesozoic (252-66 million years ago)
- Cenozoic (66 million years ago to present day)
- Unknown age



GEOLOGY

Most of East Antarctica comprises ancient igneous and metamorphic rocks such as gneiss. However, the west is formed from various younger plate fragments. The age of some of West Antarctica's rock is unknown due to the thick, impenetrable ice sheet that conceals it.

